JOHN BECK

Utah and the Times*: Governing Temporality in* Deseret

James Benning has a longstanding interest in the relationship among Western landscape, history, memory, and the politics of land use, most notably evident in, though by no means confined to, a series of text-and-image films made during the 1990s—*North on Evers* (1992), *Deseret* (1995), *Four Corners* (1997), and *UTOPIA* (1998)—and pursued in the California Trilogy consisting of *El Valley Centro* (2000), *Los* (2000), and *SOGOBI* (2001). The austerity of Benning's approach to landscape and history, with its insistence on allowing image and text (either through the insertion of the written word on screen or through spoken narration) to chafe against each other without overt directorial comment, is especially enigmatic and provocative in *Deseret*, a film concerned with the history of Utah, not least because of the distinctive, and often misunderstood (at least by non-Utahans) nature of the state's relation to the rest of the United States.

Deseret comprises a series of shots of Utah landscapes and a voice-over narration that draws on ninety-four edited extracts from reports on Utah from the *New York Times* from 1852 to 1992. The visual aspect of the film lingers over mountains, prairies, deserts, rivers and lakes; improvised dwellings, church and civic architecture; petroglyphs, industry, and highways. The verbal record covers relations with Native Americans, Brigham Young's management of the Mormon Church, conflict with the Federal Government, statehood, capital punishment, Japanese American internment, nuclear and biological weapons testing, downwinder politics, civil rights, and the culture wars. As this partial inventory suggests, the film delivers a compressed version of 150 years of Utah history (*Deseret* ends with a shot of a billboard celebrating the state centennial—"Utah—still the right place").

The film's simple structure, mimicking the form of an educational or instructional film, nevertheless generates a series of complex questions about the nature of documentary truth (through an investment in and exposure of

the limits of the photographic and journalistic record); the tension between verbal and visual representations (the photography sometimes records the sites referred to in the narration, but not always); the relationship between landscape and history (the spaces depicted are generally empty of people while the newspaper accounts are inevitably preoccupied with human activity); and the effectiveness of editing in the production of narrative (the *Times* coverage of Utah is itself selective, focusing on what is considered relevant to the East Coast; the film edits the newspaper accounts; the landscape shots are carefully collated). Together, these preoccupations challenge the viewer to undertake considerable labor in making links between image and text, narrative and pictorial composition, place and history.[1]

Deseret identifies a strange, otherworldly West. It is the West as reported in, and constructed by, the Eastern metropolitan media. It is also the peculiar West of Utah, a state with its own idiosyncratic relationship to the rest of the United States and its own distinctive version of American exceptionalism. *Deseret* allows this strangeness to emerge through the recounting of the historical record while simultaneously presenting a visual account of Utah that gestures toward deeper temporalities (geology, ancient inscriptions, the long life of toxic waste) that are no less enigmatic and ungraspable. The sense of time in *Deseret* is elastic—the stillness of the shots makes the film seem long though the length of the shots is short (and they get progressively shorter); the historical frame is short (merely a century and a half) relative to the age of the place but long in terms of the human transformation of the social and natural environment. The film, then, is very much about the management, or, to use a word with particular resonance in the Mormon vocabulary, stewardship, of time and place—through theological reckoning, government intervention, scientific experiment, historical narrative, and, in the end, through the cinematic structuring of the documentary record.

The *Times*

Benning's background in mathematics and interest in structural film governs the organization of many of his films, including *Deseret*. While he trawled all references to Utah from the *Times*, Benning selected ninety-four and pared each story down to between eight and ten sentences. Shifting language use over the course of 150 years, he has claimed, shrunk the length of the sentences over time, a fact that contributes to a certain accelerating momentum in the film since Benning uses one shot for each sentence in each story, plus one shot between each pair of stories that is presented without narration. These silent shots also get shorter. The result, explains Benning, is that the films speeds up, which, he suggests:

> corresponds with the historical realities of journalism. In the early days, stories from Utah wouldn't reach New York for three or four months. If you pay attention to the dates of the stories (the date of each story is superimposed over the first shot in each story), you'll see that, early on, the writers will be talking about something that happened in January in a story dated May: it took that long for the story to get back East. Of course, later the gap becomes a day or two days, and right now it's less than a day. (MacDonald and Benning 2005: 6)

The physical environment, then—the expansiveness of the territory, its distance from the Atlantic coast—is measured implicitly through the length of the delay between event and report, while the acceleration of technological development that shrinks physical distances (railroad, telegraph, telephone, motor vehicles) also clips the length of sentences, as if language seeks to match the efficiency of the machines. In this way, the structure of *Deseret* is to a large extent an index of these effects, the form of the film emerging from a century of shortening journey times and their cultural consequences.

The historical period covered in the film is also carefully structured. The news stories, grouped by decade, indicate that the earliest and the most recent periods predominate—over half of the ninety-four come from the first two and last two decades: twenty-two from the 1850s, nine from the 1860s, eighteen from the 1980s, and eight from the 1990s. This stress on the beginning and end of the 150-year period invites comparisons between them. One final structural aspect of the film worthy of note is that when Utah becomes a state in 1896 the film shifts from black and white to color. This splitting of the film into monochrome and color sections serves to align the first half with nineteenth-century Western landscape photography, which the composition of shots often formally echoes (MacDonald 2001: 441, n. 33). The use of color in the second section underscores the deliberate invitation to read the post-statehood twentieth century alongside the monochrome nineteenth century as two distinct epochs.

The organization of the material in *Deseret*, then, determines the way history is managed and delivered but also produces a specific temporal velocity and steers the viewer toward a comparative reading: history is apprehended as speeding up (through a compressed use of language and shrinking shot length), as amenable to slicing and stacking (there is more of the 1850s, less of the 1870s), and color-coded. The gap between event and its representation is not just there in the film and its relation to history, but also in the press report and its delayed (though shrinking) relation to the event described. The film spatializes time just as the *Times* reports are spatially removed from the Western territory on which they report. The landscape shots depict a seemingly static scene, where contemporary Utah can be made to look like nineteenth-century Utah through the use of black and white and compositional conventions associated

with that time, but the modes of representation—the selection procedures, the recitation of print sources, the editing process, the length of shot—all involve a counting off, on different scales and at different speeds, of time passing. This is a film about the times and the *Times*.

Forty-eight of the stories featured in *Deseret* allude to Mormons, and much of the focus throughout the chronology is on struggle, often violent—in the nineteenth century, between Mormons and Indians; Mormons and Indians against the Federal Government (especially during 1857, after President Buchanan, in June, declared Utah to be in rebellion against the US government and sent an expeditionary force to the territory to enforce the law under his newly appointed governor, Alfred Cumming); in the twentieth century, the struggle is increasingly between the people of Utah and the Federal Government's military-industrial presence in the state (nuclear testing, biological weapons development, and toxic-waste sites), and between a socially conservative Utah and, relatively speaking, at least, a more liberal temperament in the east. *Times* stories from the most recent decades not only reveal the persistence of the Church of Latter-day Saints' (LDS) establishment in managing Utah society but are also emblematic of the wider culture wars conducted during the late twentieth century by an ascendant political and social conservatism against the perceived permissiveness of mid-century liberalism. As the film moves toward the centennial year, then, reports from the *Times* note the exclusion of black men from the Mormon church (1978); the excommunication of Sonia Johnson for supporting the Equal Rights Amendment (1980); John Birch Society supporter Ezra Taft Benson's election as church president (1985); Aryan Nation plans to locate its headquarters in Wendover (1989); the Church's excommunication of the only Indian to achieve high standing in the state (1989); the refusal of Utah schools to remove books depicting Indians as "savages" (1988); Utah as the last state to enfranchise Native Americans (1990); and the introduction of tough anti-abortion laws (1991). Stories on polygamy, unsurprisingly, straddle the centuries (1854, 1862, 1890, 1944, 1977, 1979, 1988, 1991).

The cumulative effect of this testimony to a century of resistance to centralized authority positions Utah as, from the outset, out of step with the times (and the *New York Times*), stubbornly fighting a rearguard action against larger forces impatient and indifferent at best to its peculiar history and wayward interpretation of scriptural and national doctrine. The *New York Times* was founded on September 18, 1851, just a year after the establishment of the Utah territory on September 9, 1850. The *Times* positioned itself very much as the paper of record for the country, while Utah explicitly conceived of itself as somewhere outside the establishment. The *Times* and the territory therefore represent two distinct readings of Manifest Destiny, the belief that it was the

destiny of the US to expand to encompass all of North America. While the *Times* was invested in progressive incorporation and control from the center, the Mormons in Utah were driven by a determination to remain outside and beyond such control. Neither of these narratives comes off particularly well in *Deseret*, though there is no direct commentary that might nudge the viewer toward a view other than the blank neutrality of the presented material. Nevertheless, the film does, as my discussion of its structure begins to suggest, instantiate—as a sum of the decisions that put it together—a fairly clear measure of Eastern establishment preoccupations and prejudices as well as Utahan stubbornness.

The Shadow State

What is clear from Benning's early selections from the *Times* is that they carry in terse form the entire history of the United States as it struggles to establish cohesion and control over its rapidly expanding territories during the second half of the nineteenth century. One brief extract near the beginning of the film, dated "November 15, 1856," is instructive in this regard. Over shots of open fields, rock formations, horses grazing, desert, forest, and lake, and concluding with a herd of cattle, the voice-over recounts an abbreviated version of a story originally headlined "Law and Order in Utah":

> Brigham Young again boasts of his prowess in holding fast to the Governorship of Utah. President Pierce and his immediate supporters talk loudly of their determination to put down traitors and all who defy the laws but in Utah the laws and authority of the United States, the legality and validity of which are not disputed throughout the Union, are openly defied. Brigham Young's term of service expired nearly four years ago. Pierce promised to remove him. So much for the promise. It turns out that the effort to execute the defied laws of the United States in Utah does not amount altogether to a tithe of that expended in securing the arrest and return of a single slave.

This is a story of boasts and defiance on both sides but little action. Young and Pierce trade words, yet the stand-off continues as Young refuses to recognize the authority of the Federal Government over the territory and his leadership. The *Times* is at pains to stress the exceptional nature of the Utah situation: everywhere else the law and authority of the United States is recognized. The implication is clear that Young is a traitor, though the word is allowed in through the proclamations of the President and his supporters rather than declared directly by the newspaper. The final line, however, expands the scope of the *Times*' assessment of the situation beyond Young's stubborn illegality and Pierce's inaction.

Figure 5 *From* Deseret*, 1995 (I). Shot accompanying the sentence "So much for the promise," November 15, 1856. Courtesy of the artist and neugerriemschneider, Berlin*

The single slave the *Times* probably has in mind is Anthony Burns, who escaped slavery in 1853 and fled to Boston, where he was captured the next year under the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850. Pierce, who had supported the passage of the Act and wanted to demonstrate his resolve, sent Federal troops and artillery to Boston to ensure the prosecution of the case after abolitionists attempted to free Burns by storming the courthouse. The court remanded Burns to his owner and he was escorted under heavy Federal guard, watched by a crowd of nearly fifty thousand people, to the harbor where he was shipped back into slavery on June 2, 1854. Policing the case, identified as a turning point that galvanized the abolitionist cause, is estimated to have cost the Federal Government in excess of $40,000.

The final line of the *Times* report of November 15, 1856 used by Benning, then, radically opens the frame, as Pierce's inaction in the face of Young's defiance in Utah is placed within the national political and moral context of the President's willingness to defend, and pay for, the protection of slavery. What is not obvious from the *Times* report, though, is that by November 15 Pierce was entering his last days as President. Eighteen fifty-six was an election year, and Pierce, a northern Democrat, had failed to secure his party's nomination for re-election at the Democratic National Convention in June. Pierce's support for the Kansas–Nebraska Act, which repealed the Missouri Compromise of 1850 and allowed for the possibility of slavery in Kansas under the doctrine of popular sovereignty, not to mention his financially and politically expensive intervention in the Burns case, left him abandoned by his party. By the time the

Times is reporting Pierce's failure to oust Young in Utah, the nation had already elected, eleven days earlier, his Democratic replacement, James Buchanan.

Although Benning edits out of the *Times* report some of the political context for the comments on Young, including references to Pierce's "Jacksonian" determination to put down traitors and the hundred "freemen" languishing in a Kansas jail, also in defiance of "bogus" laws (in other words, jailed for resisting the pro-slavery territorial legislature formed after an election deemed illegal by a Congressional committee), the final sentence on the President's ineffectiveness in Utah remains supercharged. It calls forth the entire history of Westward expansion and the role of slavery in the construction of territorial and state boundaries and governments. It also demonstrates, regardless how distant Utah was from Washington or New York, how the violent and unpredictable contest over the political and moral legitimacy of the United States bound together, like nothing else, centers of power and territorial outposts, including establishment newspapers and antinomian religious sects.

As *Deseret* delivers the *Times*' account of presidential indifference toward Young's resistance to Federal authority while funding military suppression of revolt in Boston, accompanied by images of the benign indifference and pastoral tranquility of the Utah landscape, the film at once reminds viewers of the ways in which politics writes over, and into, places constructed out of it and how the depiction of landscape as unpeopled can serve as a screen to conceal the often bloody struggle for control and ownership. The grazing horses and still waters are, to an extent, manifestations of an achieved destiny that confirms nineteenth-century Federal and Mormon senses of mission. There is no visual evidence of the contested meanings of territorial sovereignty here, of the recent history of persecution that made Young and his church alive to the threat of Federal violence that had driven the sect to Utah in the first place. Nor is there evidence of the ways in which Utah's fate was, from the outset, bound up with the struggle over the right to claim other human lives as the property of free men. Part of the power of *Deseret*, then, lies in the economy with which it alludes to the politics of nation building and the ways in which landscape is the screen upon which ideology is projected and behind which the brutal clamor for meaning is concealed. Once this is registered, no aspect of the film, however innocuous or flatly presented, remains untouched by the histories it contains.

This incendiary volatility compressed into the ostensibly ordinary is as true of the film's title as it is of the verbatim accounts from the newspaper. The name Deseret is not coterminous with Utah, so the choice of the former term as the title of the film suggests a mismatch between the Mormon conception of the state and the Federal US version. Deseret, a word deriving from the Book of Mormon that refers to the industrious honey bees that characterize Mormon collective industry, is a self-designation for the proposed state outlined by

LDS Church leaders in 1849; Utah is the name of the territory as created by the US Congress in 1850. Names and origin stories are important, since the two names of the territory register contesting claims not only on the land but also on the authority that comes to define the settlement built upon it. From the outset, the Mormons knew they had to operate within the context of the Federal Government and its expansionist policies. As early as December 1847, six weeks before the signing of the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo that ended the war with Mexico and left the US in possession of California and most of Arizona, Nevada, Utah, and parts of Wyoming and Colorado, the Church leaders declared their intention to petition for a territorial government in the Great Basin "as soon as circumstances will permit." They made their first move a year later (Crawley 1989: 9).

The LDS Church petitioned Congress to create the "State of Deseret" in 1849, though the US government, preoccupied with the issue of slavery in its newly acquired territories, did not recognize the proposal. Deseret, under the Mormon proposal, encompassed most of present-day Utah and Nevada, large portions of California and Arizona, and parts of Colorado, New Mexico, Wyoming, Idaho, and Oregon. In September 1850, as part of the Compromise of 1850, the Utah Territory was created by Act of Congress. The new territory encompassed only a portion of the northern section of Deseret. On February 3, 1851, Brigham Young was inaugurated as the first governor of the Utah Territory. On April 4, the General Assembly of Deseret passed a resolution to dissolve the state, but in October the Utah territorial legislature voted to re-enact the laws and ordinances of the state of Deseret. In other words, while acknowledging the establishment of the Utah Territory, the Mormons did not relinquish the idea of a "State of Deseret."

While the possibility of creating a state based on Mormonism began to fade after the Utah War of 1857–8, when President Buchanan accomplished what Pierce did not, and the coming of the railroad opened the territory to many non-Mormon settlers, particularly in western areas, the persistence of the notion of Deseret as the true name and true authority of the territory—indeed, the "State"—reveals how deeply Young and the Church elite resisted Federal legitimacy even as their claims were overwritten by national nomenclature. It is this refusal that accounts for Young's unwillingness to step down as governor after his term ended and the *Times*' frustration with Pierce's inertia in 1856. Here, Young is claiming allegiance not only to a higher authority—it is God's will, and not government permission, that justifies his leadership—but also to the doctrine of popular sovereignty that was being used to justify the introduction of slavery into new territories. If the US government conceded that the people could decide whether or not to permit slavery on their land, it made sense for Young to claim the autonomy of his territory in choosing

its own leaders (see Turner 2016). The contest over the name of the territory, then, speaks to the question of authority and from which source it is derived. Between 1862 and 1870, under Young's leadership, a group of Church elders ran a shadow government that met after each session of the territorial legislature to ratify the new laws under the name of the "State of Deseret." Attempts were made in 1856, 1862, and 1872 to write a new state constitution under that name based on the new boundaries of the Utah Territory.

The point is that "Deseret" stands as a counter-Utah that overlaps and operates simultaneously alongside the federally recognized state. Deseret is an alternative and a refusal of Federal authority, a double and a shadow that overrides state lines and articulates an alternative, subversive, and irreducible refusal at the core of Utahan identity. "Deseret" marks the difference between how a people might see itself and how it is seen from without. In a sense, Benning's doubling of the photographic representation of Utah with *Times* reportage is an iteration of this split ontology: Utah is what it says it is (Deseret) and what the nation says it is (Utah). There is overlap between the two but they are not synonymous; nor are the congruencies necessarily comfortable. This issue of incommensurate representations—how the camera records a place and how the Eastern establishment has reported on it—is contained within the title of the film, a name that speaks of incommensurability and insubordination inside, but also adjacent to, national narratives of inclusion.

Benning's title, then, recognizes the possibility of an otherness at the heart of Utah that might also, like the expansive borders of a shadow state that is indifferent to official boundaries, encompass more than merely Utah as it is commonly known and extend to include the United States itself. As a faux educational film that delivers a "straight" account of what there is to see and what the *New York Times* says, *Deseret* performs at every level to claim flat, neutral ground. Yet as the choice of title makes clear, there is in all likelihood a shadow to every straight report, another side that speaks aslant while presenting itself unadorned. This is, I think, the case with the narrative voice.

Deseret's deadpan narrative is delivered by Fred Gardner, chosen, according to Benning, for his ability to read the *Times* reports in a neutral tone: "I wanted the language to carry the drama, rather than the *voice*" (MacDonald and Benning 2005: 6). This particular voice, though, does carry purpose. Gardner is well known as an anti-Vietnam war activist and one-time editor of *Ramparts* magazine. It was Gardner who opened the first GI coffeehouse, the UFO, in Columbia, South Carolina in 1967. More recently, he has been a vocal campaigner for the medical use of marijuana and a regular contributor to the *Anderson Valley Advertiser* (AVA), Booneville, California's weekly newspaper. The AVA is more than an average local newspaper; self-described as "America's last newspaper," since its purchase by Bruce Anderson in 1984, the *Advertiser*

has focused on environmental and political issues and has a modest national circulation. The paper's masthead borrows from the Industrial Workers of the World ("Fanning the Flames of Discontent') and Che Guevera ("¡Hasta la Victoria Siempre!"—Until victory, always).[2] The voice of the *Times* in the film, then, despite its flat delivery, represents also a particular notion of the press as an activist agent and, via the AVA, of the local newspaper as a means for a grounded challenge to orthodoxy.

While the *New York Times* stands in *Deseret* as the voice of the Eastern establishment, it is a voice inflected in the film with a more engaged conception of journalism as a counterweight to establishment values. As with the latent content of the *Times* reports and the title *Deseret* itself, the narrative voice of the film signifies more than first appears, even—indeed, perhaps especially—when the unspoken, unseen, or unacknowledged clout of that latency remains unclaimed. For while repeated viewing of the film makes it possible to detect the contraction of sentences and shots over time and enables the cross-referencing of word and image to reveal itself, there is no explanation or evidence in the film of the selection process that shaped the text, no account of the title, and no acknowledgment of who Fred Gardner is and why his voice in particular might matter. Certainly, it is possible to view *Deseret* without this information and to develop the same reading—that it is a film about land and sovereignty that stands in an ambivalent relation to the libertarian and radically conservative history of Utah. The decisions made concerning textual edits, the title, and the narrative voice confirm this reading but also underscore how the film is committed to undercutting its own performance of straightforwardness all the way down. There is nothing in *Deseret* without a shadow, however directly it is exposed to light.

Shadow as Substance

The shift to color once Utah becomes a state operates as a simple visual code to position the territorial era as a kind of prehistory: with statehood comes the full chromatic range of American modernity. This is a kind of *Wizard of Oz* effect, where the monochrome operates as a mode of historical distancing and also of authenticity, while color amplifies the spectacular and also the artificial. The Brigham Young era and the violence of national consolidation are partitioned off by the move to color as definitively past, while the contemporaneity of the color shots secures Utah as an integral part of a recognizable American present. There is more to this realignment than simple updating, though, because as the narrative moves into the twentieth century, Utah emerges as less anomalous within the national polity and instead comes to represent some of the more troubling contradictions of the corporate military-industrial state. The

reports from the *Times* increasingly focus on the use of Utah territory for the manufacture, testing, and storage of weapons, environmental despoliation, and conservative social policy. After mid-century, Utah is no longer the outlier in Federal affairs and has instead become representative of the national climate. The shadow has become substance.

A *Times* story of April 26, 1914, describing the Federal withdrawal of 18,700 acres of public land for the Utah National Guard as a "target range and maneuver grounds," prefigures the more radical extent to which the Utah was to become a component of the national security state post-World War II. Like so much of the desert West, Tooele County in northwestern Utah was valuable as a site for activities unwelcome elsewhere. Sparsely inhabited and far from areas of high population density, economically underdeveloped, politically conservative and owned mainly by the Federal Government already, the US military during World War II built the Tooele Army Depot, the Deseret Chemical Depot, and Dugway Proving Grounds (DPG) in Tooele County (Shumway and Jackson 2008: 442–3). Typical of military investment in the West during the postwar period, new bases and facilities in Tooele County provided a welcome boost to the local economy as well as confirming Utah's vital patriotic role in national defense. During World War II, DPG was the key US test site for chemical and biological weapons; though the base was phased out after the war it was reactivated during the Korean War and confirmed in 1954 as a permanent installation. A range of radiation experiments were conducted at DPG during the 1950s and, as Mike Davis notes, between 1951 and 1969 the Army conducted "1,653 field trials of nerve gas which disseminated an estimated half million pounds (or 3.5 trillion lethal doses) of the agent over Tooele County" (Davis 1998: 37). If the beleaguered history of the LDS Church in Utah represents one form of secrecy enabled by the distance of the state from the seat of Federal authority, the militarized West of the Cold War introduced a new mode of federally sanctioned secrecy to the region. While the atomic explosions at the Nevada Test Site delivered a spectacle of US power during the 1950s, promoted by the Las Vegas Chamber of Commerce with calendars containing detonation times and suggested spots for viewing, the chemical and biological work conducted in Tooele County was, and remains, top secret.

It was secret, at least, until 1968, when the death of over six thousand sheep in Skull Valley made the national press. *Deseret* offers an abbreviated account of the incident from the *Times* report of March 24:

> The head of a special investigating team said today that we are as positive as medical science can ever be that nerve gas tests conducted by the Army's top secret Dugway Proving Grounds had killed the 6,400 sheep in Utah's Skull Valley. Senator Frank Moss was told that 320 gallons of a persistent nerve gas agent was sprayed from an airplane. A compound isolated in snow, water,

> sheep blood, sheep liver tissue, and in the grass taken from sheep's stomachs is identical to that agent applied by the Army. Replying to the charge, an Army spokesman said that a separate military investigation was continuing and that no definite cause of death had been established. Meanwhile, Dr Kelly Gubler of the Tooele Valley Hospital has written in the *Medical World News* that the testing at Dugway could result in a massive human disaster.

This report is preceded by a shot of vapor rising off the land, followed by a view of the Dugway installation in the distance, a cluster of anonymous low-rise buildings flat below the mountainous horizon. Two shots of snow-covered landscape accompany the third and fourth sentences. A final shot of steam rising from cooling towers nested among rocks concludes the March 24 report. Visually, the nerve gas incident is full of airborne elements either dispersing into the atmosphere or, like the snow, redacting the ground, rocks and trees. Dugway can be plainly seen but the effect of its presence in the landscape is to introduce a disturbing unknowability to the surroundings. What is carried in the vapors that emanate from the land and is expelled from the buildings? Is the snow laced with invisible toxic agents camouflaged as nature? An entry from January 12, 1968 has reported that the CIA "recruits heavily in Utah." On August 21, 1963, President Kennedy, discussing the ban on aboveground atomic tests, avoids addressing a scientific report that has discovered high levels

Figure 6 *From* Deseret*, 1995 (II). Shot accompanying the sentence "The head of a special investigating team said today that we are as positive as medical science can ever be that nerve gas tests conducted by the Army's top secret Dugway Proving Grounds had killed the 6,400 sheep in Utah's Skull Valley," March 24, 1968. Courtesy of the artist and neugerriemschneider, Berlin*

of radioactive iodine-131 in Utah children under two years old. By the time *Deseret* gets to the nerve gas incident in 1968, Utah has already been reconfigured as a space of Federal concealment. It is little wonder that even snow is now suspect since the entire landscape has been conscripted as an agent of national security.

The Skull Valley nerve gas incident was a key moment, coinciding as it did with the rise of the environmental movement and the anti-Vietnam War protests, in the exposure of secret military activity in the US, and it led to significant restrictions in the testing of biological and chemical weapons. Like Benning's use of the November 15, 1856 report, the compressed narration of the 1968 story presented in *Deseret* reverberates beyond its local context (as regional news; as a brief segment of the film) to inform and configure the position of Utah in relation to the US, its history and politics, and the shot sequence and five sentences to the rest of the film. Subsequent *Times* reports through the 1980s and early 1990s mark the complex political and environmental challenges faced by Utah as it deals with the ongoing impact of nuclear and other military-industrial activity in the state, from soil contamination and downwinder claims to issues relating to the storage and disposal of chemical agents.

The military Keynesianism of World War II and the Cold War and the social conservatism that emerged at the end of the 1960s, reaching the highest level of government validation with the election of Ronald Reagan in 1980, complemented each other nowhere better than in the American West. Utah's history of suspicion of the Federal Government paradoxically found itself, as the national mood veered to the right, increasingly consonant with mainstream discourse. Yet what is perhaps most striking about the normalization and nationalization of Brigham Young's shadow state, as it has been upgraded into neoliberal, neoconservative consensus, is that the Mormon values of cooperation and collective effort now stand in stark critical relation to the dominant culture of the United States.[3] The Church's communitarian ethos and commitment to stewardship of the environment could not be more at odds with the duplicitous self-interest that characterizes a corporate sector that demands small government and low taxes while building its wealth from Federal contracts. The real shadow state is now, it seems, the corporate elite, which has been able to package reactionary social policy and a deregulated economy as triumphs for individual liberty.

In this regard, the kind of countercultural perspective represented by, say, Fred Gardner's journalism or, indeed, Benning's films, moves closer to Deseret as a refusnik counter-Utah—not the paranoid Deseret of Young's patriarchal theocracy but another version where the ethics of Mormonism's socialistic strain pushes back against the now nationally acceptable version of neocon,

neoliberal Utah.[4] As Jan Shipps claims, despite the perception that Utah has always been conservative, throughout the nineteenth century Mormonism "was virtually revolutionary" (Shipps 2016: 74). It is this revolutionary strain in American history that Benning has so often mobilized in order to challenge the normalized reading of American landscape as the iconography of triumphant nationalism and it is often positioned as the latent possibility of alternative readings and dissident forms. In *UTOPIA* (1998), for example, the entire soundtrack of Richard Dindo's 1994 documentary, *Ernesto Che Guevara, The Bolivian Diary*, accompanies images of the southwestern US desert. After building a replica of Thoreau's famous cabin, Benning decided to construct a second, this time a version of the cabin Ted Kaczynski, the Unabomber, lived in (see Ault 2011). As with the doubling of Deseret and Utah—the imagined territory and the official one—the purpose of these jarring combinations is, as Jeffrey Skoller writes in relation to *UTOPIA*, to conjure "potential histories." The focus, claims Skoller, is placed "less on what is possible to actualize than on the complex interplay between events that actually did happen and what can be imagined or desired in relation to them" (Skoller 2005: 101). In *Deseret*, Benning draws out of the Mormon legacy, so effectively undermined by decades of establishment disdain, another, unrealized Utah of collectivist struggle and defiant independence. *Deseret*, then, refuses to allow the conventional narrative of a shared national interest, as captured in the aloof perspective of the *New York Times*, to pass unchallenged. The revolutionary impulse Benning finds in Utah is far from unimpeachable, but it is there, especially during the resistance to Federal Government in the nineteenth century, when the ideological foreclosures of nationalist territorial expansion were as yet incomplete. In the attempt to found an alternative social order and in the refusal to yield to centralized power, Deseret, if not Utah, offered another definition of how it might be possible to live in America, an imagined or desired territory that persists as the shadow of the actually existing United States.

That shadow darkened during the twentieth century, and especially in the years following World War II. The strident anticommunism of Ezra Taft Benson, President Eisenhower's Secretary for Agriculture and later President of the LDS Church, contributed during the 1950s to a conscious disowning of Mormon communitarianism, bolting together Mormon and American exceptionalism in order to claim that America was, as Taft claimed, "the Lord's base of operations" (quoted in Barlow 2016: 108). Yet it is only since 1984 that the state has been steadfastly Republican in state and presidential elections (Shipps 2016: 74).[5] The intuition that there are other histories beyond the official narrative of national consensus, histories that are never entirely buried, is why *Deseret*, I think, never straightens out the strangeness of Utah, never judges its legacy or its peculiarities. In fact, it is precisely Utah's strangeness—its

resilience, awkwardness, and its socialistic, utopian willingness to imagine the world otherwise—that makes it essential for Benning, both as a counter-legacy at odds with the familiar narrative of the Western United States as a default conservative heartland, and as a shadow state bent on building another America.

Notes

1. The form of *Deseret* is discussed by Anderson (2011: 117–19) and MacDonald (2001: 338–44).
2. On the *Anderson Valley Advertiser*, see Nazaryan (2015)
3. On the relation between neoliberalism and neoconservatism, see Brown (2006).
4. As a text that imagines the possibility of a dissident West at odds with the dominant national discourse, *Deseret* bears comparison with the kind of environmental nonfiction produced out of Utah by, for example, Terry Tempest Williams (1991) and Ellen Meloy (1999). For further discussion of Williams, Meloy and others in relation to post-World War II military-industrial environmental despoliation, see Beck (2009).
5. At the end of the 1960s, for example, only between 18 and 21 percent of Utahn Mormons described themselves as "conservative Republicans," and loyalty to the Republican Party was no stronger in Utah than elsewhere in the West. The 1976 presidential election marks a turning point, with Utah holding fast to the Republicans while the rest of the country, post-Watergate, swung to the Democrats. During the Reagan era, the Republican hold on Utah hardened; in 1984 three-quarters of Utah voted for Reagan (Campbell et al. 2016: 138–9).

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